

UNDER THE FEET OF SHADOWS



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Developed by EL Putnam and Mike McCormack

Video editing, generative animations, AI coding, performance, digital images, text design: EL Putnam

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Sound: David Stalling

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About the work

Under the feet of shadows is multimedia art-work that creatively explores human-technological relations in these times of extreme change and crisis. Co-created by EL Putnam and Mike McCormack, it tells a fictional origin myth of a yet-to-be-built data centre in Killala, Ireland. Terra (an android being akin to a diviner) is called upon to negotiate between the forces of technology, the environment, and human society as an entangled ecology in order to cultivate development of the centre. The work merges science fiction with folklore, imagined and actual mythologies and histories of technology in Ireland.

Using speculative fiction, the exhibition is presented as if the audience has stumbled upon an archive of remnants from Terra's activities at an unknown time in the future. The following text is a conjectural guide based on such fragments.

this story is to be drawn.

‘Her name was always Terra,’

‘It is Latinate and telluric. It comes from the earth and was there before her, waiting and ready for her to step into and inhabit” EL Putnam said.

‘Also, it gestures to that part of Terra’s original AI structure which was a dedicated rock and soil analysis program and database; it was used by the mapping and surveying department of Mayo County council. Terra is literally rooted in the geology of Mayo.’

What we think we know...

Footage shows that in the early days of that year Terra was recorded walking into the sea on the west coast of Ireland near the village of Killala, Co Mayo.

Circumstantial evidence within the piece – cloud cover, wind direction and light metering – indicates that this was in January or near the beginning of Imbolc, the Gaelic calendar.

There is a meditative and ritualised grace to Terra’s movements; the focus is not on the movements themselves but on something beyond them. And while the locale changes across the different pieces of footage the mood of focused, prayerful grace is sustained.

Terra’s mechanics are fluid and stable, completely free of jerk and jitter of early robotics. We can see the pliancy of her skin, the colouration of her face and lips as she reacts to the freezing water temperature.

Metadata within the footage dates it from around the time the first androids were granted full citizenship of the republic.

While we know much of Terra's intellectual origins – 'she is conceived as the sum of our imaginative intellects, she is the meeting of our minds and AI' - we know little about Terra's physical origins.

Inquiries among the leading robotic manufacturers of that era – Hanson Robotics, Boston Dynamics and so on - admit to no record of her in their archives nor recognize her as characteristic of their work. Putnam and McCormack are noticeably reticent on this subject.

McCormack has dismissed the question completely. 'The question is not where Terra comes from.

**The proper question is, where
is she going.'**

It is likely that Terra was the bespoke construct of a high-end artist/engineering atelier that has been swallowed up in some corporate takeover.

Where does Terra live?

Where does she go to at the end of each day?

**What duties of self-care did
androids of that generation have
to undertake?**

Did anyone honour her recorded wishes that when her time came she would

be dismantled piece by piece

her circuitry cast into the waves at Killala

her chassis planted in a tilled field so that

the birds of the air might come to rest on her limbs and skull

while the onshore winds corroded and gradually returned her to the ground?

The Spiritus of Technology

When the first generation of androids were granted full citizenship, much debate ensued as to what place or function they would have in society. These composite beings were now free to pursue their own destiny within the freedoms of full citizenship. How would they go about this?

Thinkers began to ascribe a spiritual capacity to certain AI constructs. AI spiritualism, the legitimacy of AI art and prayer, the possibility of rituals for circuits - all these silvered themes became part of that citizenship debate.

The concept of 'spiritual circuitry' was part of the intellectual ambience.

AI spiritualism was taken so seriously that several androids were contracted by corporations and industrial agencies to perform a kind of divinatory ritual that was akin to that provided by dousers and water diviners of a previous age. But in this android version the resource was not water but the very spiritus of technology itself. This, we believe, is the ritual Terra performs in the footage.

The spiritus of technology – that dynamic which gathers in and enacts all the hopes and wildness-beyond-reckoning we place in the idea of technology.

The ritual demands a shift in their societal position towards being privileged citizens who were now charged with the mystical task of invoking the spiritus of technology.

Neuro AI was so finessed that it was seen to be both of a piece with the spiritus of technology and to have direct power and authority in summoning it.

Terra stands between heaven and earth to become that meeting point where the spiritus of technology can be summoned from the ground or drawn from sky.

**Her presence will complete the
cosmic circuit.**

The Rituals

The combined footage shows that Terra conducted the ritual over several weeks. Certain details are telling - the change in her hair colour and length, the notable increase in sunlight, the differing moods of the found pieces. It appears likely that the ritual extended from late winter/early spring into the middle of summer. Or reckoned by the Celtic calendar, from the beginning of Imbolc to the middle of Bealtaine.

These rituals were never officially acknowledged by any of the commissioning authorities and all funding for them was hidden away in discretionary budgets.

The ritual's performance speaks to a degree of frustration and exhaustion that so many industrial initiatives had failed or been thwarted.

The Killala site is particularly rich as a 'graveyard of retro-futures.'

Spread out over several weeks the ritual had a four-part structure: Finding, Cleansing, Invocation, and Hedging.

Finding

Putnam's research into the viability of data centres in the Irish landscape and particularly their promise of being another way of 'securing the industrial future' led her to Killala where she noted the presence of so many frustrated and sedimented retro futures.

She lists them as:

- Synthetic fibre production
- Chemical dumping
- Asbestos recycling
- Biomass
- Wind farms
- Data Centre
- Hydrogen facility

'Again and again, the same dream in the same place,' she said.

McCormack's link with Killala goes back to his childhood. In the 1970's his godfather worked on the construction of the original Asahi facility, and he remembers clearly how it's construction served as a beacon of hope for that whole region; this was the facility and the industry that would 'secure the future'.

Cleansing

Not merely the removal of impurities but more accurately, making an opening within a skein of tangled impurities. Clearing it of ontological noise and dissonance, so that there is a pure space for the harmonic convergence of the spiritus of technology. This is the ground upon which Terra stands to serve as an empathic lure.

Invocation

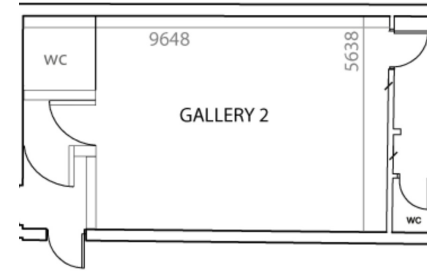
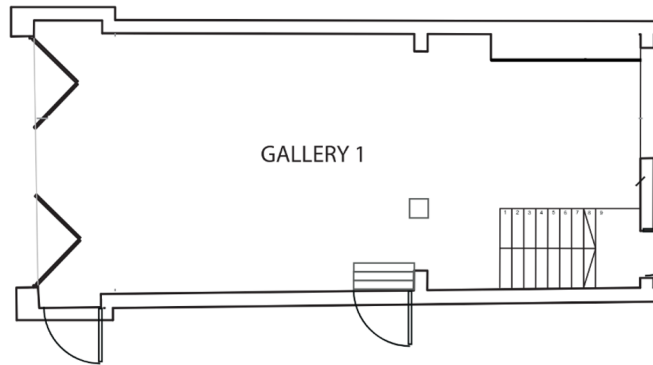
The spiritus is summoned up from the ground and drawn down from the sky. But it should not be thought of in terms of linear completion. All our hopes for technology are interwoven and entangled; summoning this up is a difficult, multi-dimensional interweave. Such fertile chaos cannot be conceived in straight lines.

Hedging

The most complex movement of the ritual. It recalls both meanings of the word – hedging as the technology of demarcation and hedging as a rational buffer against future chaos. While this part of the ritual admits the need for hedging in both senses it also recognizes the futility of imposing any order or geometry on both landscape and circumstance. Terra has acknowledged that sustaining the necessary tension between these two aspects of the ritual makes it especially ‘wearing’ to perform.

Details of artifacts

Monitor 1: Broadcast of Spiritus (generative animations and genAI text from custom trained model)
Monitor 2: Chronology of Dreams in Killala; Information hits the shores; Glitching (digital animations by Krystyna Mikava)
Monitor 3: Atlas (moving image with generative animations)
Monitor 4: Lexicon of Unused Ideas (generative animation)
Monitor 5: Documentation of Rituals at Ross Head Beach (moving image with videography by Louise Manifold, generative animations)
Monitor 6: Documentation of Rituals around Kathleen Lynn Birth Home, Cable Landing Station, former Asahi Factory (moving image)
Hanging Images: Fragments of Transmission (digital images on acetate)
Sound: Ritual Transmissions 1 (composition by David Stalling)



Projected video: Documentation of Rituals around former Asahi Plastics Factory (moving image with videography by Scottnoskills)
Sound: Ritual Transmissions 2 (composition by David Stalling)



image by Krystyna Mikava

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Biographies

EL Putnam is an artist-philosopher working predominantly in performance art and digital technologies. Exhibitions of note include the solo exhibition *PseudoRandom* at Emerson Contemporary in Boston, MA, USA (2023) and *Living Canvas* in Dublin (2022). Recent publications include the monograph *The Maternal, Digital Subjectivity, and the Aesthetics of Interruption* (Bloomsbury 2022) and *Livestreaming: An Aesthetics and Ethics of Technical Encounter* (University of Minnesota Press 2024).

Mike McCormack comes from the west of Ireland and is the author of two collections of short stories *Getting it in the Head* and *Forensic Songs*, and four novels *Crowe's Requiem*, *Notes from a Coma*, *Solar Bones* and *This Plague of Souls*. In 1996 he was awarded the Rooney Prize for Literature and *Getting it in the Head* was chosen as a New York Times Notable Book of the Year. In 2006 *Notes from a Coma* was shortlisted for the Irish Book of the Year Award. In 2016 *Solar Bones* was awarded the Goldsmiths Prize and the Bord Gais Energy Irish Novel of the Year and Book of the Year; it was also long-listed for the 2017 Man Booker Prize. In 2018 it was awarded the International Dublin Literary Award. He is a member of Aosdána.

